

Modern cities

Today, more than half of the world's population lives in cities, drawn by the opportunities for work and wealth. As a result, many cities are now very large. Not all of this growth has been planned, however, and cities in developing countries are sometimes fringed by sprawling shantytowns with poor housing and no proper services.

New York

United States of America

Area 303 sq miles (786 sq km)

Population 8.4 million

Founding date 1609

Originally a Dutch colony known as New Amsterdam, New York's name changed when it was surrendered to the English in 1664. Its huge natural harbor on the Atlantic coast made it an important trading port, and it became the main point of entry for European immigrants to the United States. New York is now the largest

and most prosperous city in North America, and is famous worldwide as a financial, commercial, and cultural center.

▼ THE BIG APPLE

The high-rise skyline of New York City is an emblem of American wealth and aspiration.



Rio de Janeiro

Brazil

Area 462 sq miles (1,198 sq km)

Population 6.3 million

Founding date 1565

Rio is the second largest city in Brazil, and the most spectacular. It lies along the shores of Guanabara Bay on the Atlantic coast, famous for its dramatic granite landscapes and beautiful beaches. Rio Carnival is the largest festival of its kind in the world, and attracts millions of tourists every year.

